RELATIONSHIPS

Friendship Flags Checklist

How to recognize healthy friendships, red flags, and everything in between

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A Note from Dr. Hala

Dear reader,

Friendships shape your life more than most people realize. The people you surround yourself with influence your mood, your self-esteem, your decisions, and even your future. But not all friendships are created equal, and not all of them are good for you.

This checklist is designed to help you evaluate your friendships with clarity and compassion. It is not about cutting people off at the first sign of trouble. It is about understanding what healthy connection looks like so you can invest your energy wisely.

With warmth, **Dr. Hala Ali** *Family & Youth Counselor*

Section 1: Green Flags in Friendships

These are signs that a friendship is healthy and worth nurturing.

- [ ] They celebrate your wins without jealousy
- [ ] You can be yourself around them without performing
- [ ] They respect your boundaries when you say no
- [ ] They check on you, not just when they need something
- [ ] Conversations go both ways, they listen as much as they talk
- [ ] They apologize when they mess up, sincerely
- [ ] You feel energized, not drained, after spending time together
- [ ] They keep your secrets and respect your privacy
- [ ] They support your growth even when it means you are changing
- [ ] Disagreements are handled with respect, not manipulation
- [ ] They show up consistently, not just when it is convenient
- [ ] They are happy for you even when things are not going well for them
- [ ] They tell you the truth, even when it is hard to hear, but they do it kindly

What Green Flags Look Like in Real Life

- You tell them about a good grade, and they say "That is amazing, you worked so hard" instead of "Must be nice" or changing the subject.
- You say no to plans, and they respond with "No worries, next time" without guilt-tripping you.
- You are going through a hard time, and they check in without being asked. They do not just say "Let me know if you need anything." They actually show up.
- You disagree about something, and afterward you both feel heard, even if you did not change each other's minds.

Reflection

How many of these describe your closest friendship? _____ / 13

If most of them apply, you have something worth protecting and investing in.

Section 2: Yellow Flags to Watch

These are not dealbreakers, but they are worth paying attention to. Yellow flags are patterns that may be pointing toward a problem.

- [ ] They cancel plans frequently without explanation
- [ ] They only reach out when they need something
- [ ] They make jokes at your expense and call it humor
- [ ] They are hot and cold, super close one week, distant the next
- [ ] They gossip about others to you (which means they gossip about you to others)
- [ ] They compete with you instead of supporting you
- [ ] They dismiss your feelings with phrases like "you are overreacting"
- [ ] They pressure you to do things you are not comfortable with
- [ ] They get upset when you spend time with other people
- [ ] You find yourself making excuses for their behavior
- [ ] They leave you on read regularly but expect instant replies from you
- [ ] They copy your ideas, style, or interests without acknowledging it
- [ ] They are only kind to you in private but distant or different in groups

What Yellow Flags Look Like in Real Life

- You share something you are excited about, and they one-up you with something bigger.
- You express that something hurt your feelings, and they respond with "I was just joking, you are so sensitive."
- They are your best friend one week and barely acknowledge you the next, and you are always left wondering what changed.
- They text you constantly when they need advice about their problems, but when you need to talk, they are suddenly busy.

What To Do About Yellow Flags

Yellow flags do not mean you should end the friendship immediately. They mean you should:

1. **Pay attention to patterns.** One bad day is not a yellow flag. A repeated pattern is.
2. **Check your own role.** Are you communicating your needs, or hoping they will read your mind?
3. **Have an honest conversation.** Use the scripts in Section 5 to bring it up.
4. **Watch how they respond.** A friend who hears you and tries to change is worth keeping. A friend who dismisses your concerns or turns it around on you is showing you a red flag.

Reflection

How many of these describe a friendship you are in right now? _____ / 13

If you checked five or more, this friendship needs a conversation. Not necessarily an ending, but a conversation.

Section 3: Red Flags That Demand Action

These are signs that a friendship is harmful and may need to end.

- [ ] They manipulate you emotionally to get what they want
- [ ] They share your private information with others
- [ ] They put you down consistently, in private or in public
- [ ] They try to isolate you from other friends or family
- [ ] They use guilt to control your behavior
- [ ] They are physically intimidating or aggressive
- [ ] They pressure you into illegal or dangerous activities

- [ ] They refuse to take responsibility for hurting you
- [ ] You feel worse about yourself because of this friendship
- [ ] You feel afraid of their reaction if you set a boundary
- [ ] They threaten to hurt themselves if you try to distance yourself
- [ ] They use your secrets against you during arguments
- [ ] They make you feel like everything is your fault

What Red Flags Look Like in Real Life

- You try to hang out with another friend, and they get angry, give you the silent treatment, or say things like "I guess I am not enough for you."
- They share a screenshot of your private conversation with other people to make you look bad.
- They say things like "No one else would put up with you" or "You are lucky I am your friend."
- When you try to talk about something they did that hurt you, they turn it around: "Well, you did this to me first" or "You are always starting drama."
- You walk on eggshells around them, always afraid of their reaction.

What To Do About Red Flags

Red flags are not things you fix with a conversation. They are signs that this friendship is causing harm to your well-being. Here is what to consider:

1. **You do not owe anyone a friendship that costs you your mental health.**
2. **Talk to a trusted adult** (parent, counselor, teacher) about what you are experiencing. You do not have to handle this alone.
3. **Create distance gradually** if ending it abruptly feels unsafe. You do not need a dramatic confrontation.
4. **Document what is happening** if the behavior is threatening or you feel unsafe. Keep screenshots or notes with dates.
5. **Remember that their behavior is not your fault.** You did not cause it and you cannot fix it.

Reflection

If you checked even two or three of these, this friendship may be causing real harm. You deserve better, and seeking support to navigate this is not weakness. It is one of the bravest things you can do.

Section 4: My Friendship Audit Worksheet

Take a few minutes to evaluate your closest friendships. This is for your eyes only.

Friendship 1

Name: _____

How long we have been friends: _____

Green flags I see in this friendship: _____

Yellow or red flags I have noticed: _____

How I feel after spending time with them (honestly): _____

Is there something I need to say to them? _____

Overall, this friendship is: Healthy / Needs attention / Harmful

Friendship 2

Name: _____

How long we have been friends: _____

Green flags I see in this friendship: _____

Yellow or red flags I have noticed: _____

How I feel after spending time with them (honestly): _____

Is there something I need to say to them? _____

Overall, this friendship is: Healthy / Needs attention / Harmful

Friendship 3

Name: _____

How long we have been friends: _____

Green flags I see in this friendship: _____

Yellow or red flags I have noticed: _____

How I feel after spending time with them (honestly): _____

Is there something I need to say to them? _____

Overall, this friendship is: Healthy / Needs attention / Harmful

Section 5: How to Have the Conversation

Having hard conversations with friends takes courage. Here are scripts you can adapt to your own situation and style.

If You Need to Set a Boundary

The situation: They keep making jokes about something that hurts you.

What to say: "Hey, I know you probably do not mean anything by it, but when you joke about _____, it actually bothers me. I would appreciate it if you could stop. It would mean a lot."

The situation: They expect you to be available all the time.

What to say: "I care about our friendship, but I need you to understand that sometimes I need space or time with other people. That does not mean I care about you less."

The situation: They pressure you to do something you are uncomfortable with.

What to say: "I have already said no, and I need you to respect that. A real friend does not keep pushing after I have been clear."

If You Need to Address a Pattern

The situation: They only reach out when they need something.

What to say: "I have noticed that we mostly talk when you need help with something, and I am happy to be there for you, but I need this to go both ways. I want to feel like you care about what is going on in my life too."

The situation: They are hot and cold.

What to say: "I have been confused by our friendship lately. Sometimes it feels really close, and other times it feels distant. Can we talk about what is going on? I would rather know than keep guessing."

If You Need to Step Back

What to say: "I have been doing some thinking about what I need right now, and I need to take some space. This is not about blame. It is about taking care of myself."

If they ask why: "I do not think our friendship is bringing out the best in either of us right now. I need some time to figure out what I need."

If You Need to End It

Not every friendship needs a dramatic ending. Sometimes the healthiest thing is to gradually reduce contact and invest your energy elsewhere. You do not owe anyone a friendship that costs you your peace.

But if you want to be direct: "I have thought about this a lot, and I do not think this friendship is healthy for me. I wish you well, but I need to move on."

What If They React Badly?

- Their reaction is not your responsibility. You are only responsible for being honest and kind.
- If they try to guilt you, that confirms your decision, not contradicts it.
- If they spread rumors or try to turn others against you, talk to a trusted adult.
- If you feel unsafe, do not do this alone. Get support first.

Section 6: Building Better Friendships

Evaluating your friendships is only half the work. The other half is learning how to be a good friend and how to find people who bring out your best.

How to Be a Green Flag Friend

- Check in on people without being asked
- Celebrate their wins even when you are struggling
- Listen without always trying to fix
- Keep their secrets
- Apologize sincerely when you mess up
- Respect their time, boundaries, and other friendships
- Tell the truth with kindness

How to Find Your People

- Join activities based on genuine interests, not popularity
- Be the kind of friend you want to have
- Give new friendships time to develop, depth takes months, not days
- Look for consistency, not intensity. A steady friend is more valuable than a dramatic one
- Pay attention to how people treat others, not just how they treat you

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A Final Word

You teach people how to treat you. Every time you accept behavior that does not feel right, you are sending a message about what you will tolerate. And every time you set a boundary, you are sending a message about what you are worth.

You deserve friendships that feel safe, mutual, and genuine. You deserve people who are happy to see you, who make space for your feelings, and who want you to grow. If a friendship does not meet that standard, it is okay to let it go. And it is okay to grieve it, even if you know it was the right decision.

Your peace matters. Your feelings matter. And the right people will never make you question that.

This toolkit is for educational purposes and does not replace professional counseling. If you are in a friendship that feels abusive or unsafe, please reach out to a trusted adult or a qualified mental health professional.

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